up at the Temple gate. “If any one within can refute these principles,” he said, “I will then give my head as a proof of his victory.”’ When several days passed by and no one at Nalanda responded, Xuanzang sent an attendant to tear down his theses, ‘trample it under foot’, and invite the Brahmin to a debate. A great number of Nalanda priests gathered ‘whilst he disputed with the Brahmin’. The debate soon left the Brahmin ‘silent and unable to reply’. Rising up, ‘he respectfully said: “I am overcome; I am ready to abide by the former compact.”’ Xuanzang, claiming to espouse non-violence, magnanimously pardoned his life.[26]

There were more extreme ‘heretics’ too, such as Shashanka of Bengal, a Brahminical king, who ‘slandered the religion of the Buddha’ and raided and ‘cut down the Bodhi tree’, ‘burnt it with fire’ and destroyed the monasteries around it, though he couldn’t fully destroy the roots of the tree. Thankfully, writes Xuanzang, the king of Magadh lovingly nurtured the roots ‘with the milk of a thousand cows’, causing the tree to miraculously revive within months.

Xuanzang, in particular, but also Faxian and Yijing, travelled extensively in India, not just to the famous pilgrimage sites. ‘All over India,’ writes Yijing, ‘there are innumerable big monasteries.’ Their accounts suggest that Buddhism was well established (though Xuanzang also saw ruined monasteries in some places, perhaps indicating the start of Buddhism’s long-term decline in India). From Kashmir to Sri Lanka, they saw old and new Buddhist sites and thousands of monasteries hosting perhaps hundreds of thousands of monks split between Mahayana and the eighteen sects of Hinayana (or Theravada, the preferred term now). These monks were of course drawn from a *much larger* pool of lay Buddhists.

Such a large number of Buddhists, their institutions and monasteries were sustained in part by a culture of royal patronage and evangelism inaugurated by Ashoka for his newfound faith, and later continued even by Brahminical kings such as the Ikshvakus, the Satavahanas, the Guptas, and, of course, by Buddhist kings such as Kanishka and others of the Kushan Dynasty, Harsha, the Palas and others. But it seems clear that the Chinese pilgrims spent far more time in urban areas, which tended to have a higher density of Buddhists. According to archaeologist-scholar Lars Fogelin, Jainism and Buddhism ‘allowed merchants and traders to more easily